

Listening for God's Direction

You may answer privately, in prayer, without writing everything down. Keep a brief note only of anything you intend to test later. Unless immediate safety requires it, make no major or irreversible decision on retreat.

1 • Check-in

1. God asked Elijah, "What are you doing here?" Answer it for yourself, honestly, in a few sentences. Not why you came, but what you are actually doing here, now, on the third morning.

2. In the past, what have you understood as God's guidance? Looking back, what fruit, correction, confirmation, or later evidence helped you evaluate it?

3. Is there a decision, a direction, or a question you have been hoping this retreat would settle? Write it in one line.

4. What does Scripture already say about that matter, as far as you know? If you are not sure, write that down; it is the first thing to find out.

3 • Silence

Twenty minutes, or ten, or five. Anchor phrase: "Speak, Lord, for your servant hears." Or: "Here I am." Attention is the practice; the outcome is not yours to produce.

4 • Journal

1. Write down, without editing, anything you sensed during the silence: a verse, a thought, a phrase, a picture, a direction, or nothing. Do not decide yet whether it was God.

2. Did anything seem corrective, encouraging, clarifying, or unresolved? Do not force one of these categories if nothing significant emerged.

3. For anything significant, go through the tests and mark each one “supports”, “raises concern”, “not yet examined”, or “requires qualified advice”. Nothing is confirmed until those checks are complete, and several of them cannot be completed on a retreat.

4. Who is a mature, trustworthy Christian who knows Scripture, understands your situation, respects appropriate boundaries, and has no interest in controlling your decision? For medical, legal, financial, or abuse-related matters, who has the relevant competence? If you do not have such people, who could you begin to ask?

The tests (for anything significant)

Test	Supports	Concern	Not yet	Advice
Does it agree with Scripture, read in context?				
Does it reflect the character and fruit of Christ?				
Is it truthful about facts, not merely feelings?				
Does it withstand time and careful questioning?				
What do mature and appropriately qualified advisers say?				
Does it respect safety, consent, justice, and accountability?				
Does it require secrecy, superiority, recklessness, or immunity from challenge?				
Is the proposed action proportionate and reversible?				
Are you sufficiently rested, regulated, informed, and supported to decide?				

5 • Listening with Scripture

Passage (or Psalm 25:4–10, Proverbs 3:5–8, James 1:5–8): _____

1. After the first reading, notice which word or phrase stands out to you. Do not analyse why. Write it down.
 2. After the second reading, ask what that word or phrase is saying in its own context, to its original hearers. Read the verses around it. If you do not know the historical or literary context, write “I need to study this” rather than guessing, and use a reliable study Bible or commentary after the retreat. Write a sentence.
 3. After the third reading, ask what it might be saying to you, in your situation, in light of your question. Write that down too, and mark it clearly as what I sense, not what God said.
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Card to cut out · keep it with your Session 3 cards

What I sense:

What I will test it against: the tests, and the people I will consult

6 · Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

God has spoken authoritatively in Scripture, and I will begin there.

I have brought my question honestly without demanding an immediate answer.

Any impression I recorded remains an impression until it has been tested.

I will seek wise and appropriately qualified counsel.

I will not use God's name to justify harm, haste, secrecy, or escape.

If faithful responsibility calls me back, I will respond with wisdom, safety, and support.